

Mobilizing Rhetoric

Cheap Talk, Credibility, and Repression

Gaétan Nandong
New York University

APSA
September 2026

Motivation

- ▶ How do opposition leaders persuade followers to turn out?

Motivation

- ▶ How do opposition leaders persuade followers to turn out?

- ▶ Existing explanations emphasize:

(Bueno de Mesquita [2010](#); Chen and Suen [2021](#); DeNardo [1985](#); Olson [1965](#); Shadmehr [2015](#); Shadmehr and Bernhardt [2019](#))

- ▶ selective incentives;
- ▶ revolutionary agendas; and
- ▶ coercion and violence.

Motivation

- ▶ How do opposition leaders persuade followers to turn out?
- ▶ Existing explanations emphasize:
(Bueno de Mesquita [2010](#); Chen and Suen [2021](#); DeNardo [1985](#); Olson [1965](#); Shadmehr [2015](#); Shadmehr and Bernhardt [2019](#))
 - ▶ selective incentives;
 - ▶ revolutionary agendas; and
 - ▶ coercion and violence.
- ▶ **Limitation:** Opposition organizations are often materially weak.

Motivation

- ▶ How do opposition leaders persuade followers to turn out?
- ▶ Existing explanations emphasize:
(Bueno de Mesquita [2010](#); Chen and Suen [2021](#); DeNardo [1985](#); Olson [1965](#); Shadmehr [2015](#); Shadmehr and Bernhardt [2019](#))
 - ▶ selective incentives;
 - ▶ revolutionary agendas; and
 - ▶ coercion and violence.
- ▶ **Limitation:** Opposition organizations are often materially weak.
- ▶ This paper studies **public communication**:

Motivation

- ▶ How do opposition leaders persuade followers to turn out?
- ▶ Existing explanations emphasize:
(Bueno de Mesquita 2010; Chen and Suen 2021; DeNardo 1985; Olson 1965; Shadmehr 2015; Shadmehr and Bernhardt 2019)
 - ▶ selective incentives;
 - ▶ revolutionary agendas; and
 - ▶ coercion and violence.
- ▶ **Limitation:** Opposition organizations are often materially weak.
- ▶ This paper studies **public communication**:
 - ▶ *value-of-victory rhetoric* (Freedom; democracy; liberation)

Motivation

- ▶ How do opposition leaders persuade followers to turn out?
- ▶ Existing explanations emphasize:
(Bueno de Mesquita 2010; Chen and Suen 2021; DeNardo 1985; Olson 1965; Shadmehr 2015; Shadmehr and Bernhardt 2019)
 - ▶ selective incentives;
 - ▶ revolutionary agendas; and
 - ▶ coercion and violence.
- ▶ **Limitation:** Opposition organizations are often materially weak.
- ▶ This paper studies **public communication**:
 - ▶ *value-of-victory rhetoric* (Freedom; democracy; liberation)
- ▶ **Question:** How can cheap-talk communication mobilize protest and help citizens confront state repression?

Model: Citizens

- ▶ One leader and a continuum of citizens indexed by $i \in [0, 1]$.
- ▶ The leader sends one of two public messages: $m_1 \equiv$ “mobilize” or $m_2 \equiv$ “do not mobilize”.
- ▶ Each citizen chooses $a_i \in \{0, 1\}$, where $a_i = 1$ denotes participation.

$$A = \int_0^1 a_i di$$

Model: Citizens

- ▶ One leader and a continuum of citizens indexed by $i \in [0, 1]$.
- ▶ The leader sends one of two public messages: $m_1 \equiv$ “mobilize” or $m_2 \equiv$ “do not mobilize”.
- ▶ Each citizen chooses $a_i \in \{0, 1\}$, where $a_i = 1$ denotes participation.

$$A = \int_0^1 a_i \, di$$

- ▶ The net payoff from participation is

$$KS(A)V - R - c_i,$$

V : value of victory; R : repression; $c_i \sim \mathcal{U}[0, C]$: private participation cost; $K > 0$.

$S(A)$ is the probability of success.

Model: Leader

$$u_\ell(A, R) = \begin{cases} B - R, & \text{if } A \geq T, \\ -R, & \text{if } A < T. \end{cases}$$

- ▶ $T \in (0, 1)$ is the mobilization-recognition threshold.
- ▶ $B > 0$ is the benefit from reaching a politically consequential level of turnout.

Examples: filling Tahrir Square or bringing a national strike to critical mass.

Model: Political State

- ▶ Two-dimensional state space

$$V \times R = \{(v^L, 1), (v^L, r), (v^H, 1), (v^H, r)\}.$$

- ▶ $V \in \{v^L, v^H\}$ is the value of successful political change, with $\Pr(V = v^H) = 1/2$.
- ▶ $R \in \{1, r\}$ is the level of repression, with $\Pr(R = 1) = 1/2$.

Model: Political State

- ▶ Two-dimensional state space

$$V \times R = \{(v^L, 1), (v^L, r), (v^H, 1), (v^H, r)\}.$$

- ▶ $V \in \{v^L, v^H\}$ is the value of successful political change, with $\Pr(V = v^H) = 1/2$.
- ▶ $R \in \{1, r\}$ is the level of repression, with $\Pr(R = 1) = 1/2$.
- ▶ The two dimensions are independent and privately observed by the leader.

$$1 < v^L < r < v^H.$$

The parameter r measures the severity of repression.

Timing

1. Nature selects (V, R) , which is privately observed by the leader.
2. The leader sends a public message $m \in \{m_1, m_2\}$.
3. Citizens observe m and their private costs.
4. Citizens simultaneously choose $a_i \in \{0, 1\}$.
5. Payoffs are realized. The probability of success is

$$S(A) = S(0) + \beta A.$$

$\beta \geq 0$ measures the strength of strategic complementarity.

Participation Incentives

After message m , citizens form the posterior beliefs

$$\overline{V}(m) = \mathbb{E}[V \mid m], \quad \overline{R}(m) = \mathbb{E}[R \mid m].$$

The expected payoff from participating is

$$U_i = K(S(0) + \beta A)\overline{V}(m) - \overline{R}(m) - c_i.$$

Participation Incentives

After message m , citizens form the posterior beliefs

$$\overline{V}(m) = \mathbb{E}[V \mid m], \quad \overline{R}(m) = \mathbb{E}[R \mid m].$$

The expected payoff from participating is

$$U_i = K(S(0) + \beta A)\overline{V}(m) - \overline{R}(m) - c_i.$$

$$\frac{\partial U_i}{\partial A} = K\beta\overline{V}(m).$$

Equilibrium Turnout

For an interior turnout equilibrium,

$$CA(m) = K(S(0) + \beta A(m))\bar{V}(m) - \bar{R}(m).$$

Solving the fixed point gives

$$A(m) = \frac{KS(0)\bar{V}(m) - \bar{R}(m)}{C - K\beta\bar{V}(m)}.$$

Equilibrium Turnout

For an interior turnout equilibrium,

$$CA(m) = K(S(0) + \beta A(m))\bar{V}(m) - \bar{R}(m).$$

Solving the fixed point gives

$$A(m) = \frac{KS(0)\bar{V}(m) - \bar{R}(m)}{C - K\beta\bar{V}(m)}.$$

Without strategic complementarity, $\beta = 0$:

$$A(m) = \frac{KS(0)\bar{V}(m) - \bar{R}(m)}{C}.$$

Without Strategic Complementarity

$$\beta = 0$$

- Consider a message that raises $\bar{V}(m)$

$$\begin{array}{c} \text{Direct effect on participation} \\ \downarrow \\ A(m) = \frac{KS(0)\bar{V}(m) - \bar{R}(m)}{C}. \end{array}$$

$$\frac{\partial A(m)}{\partial \bar{V}(m)} = \frac{KS(0)}{C}.$$

A higher expected value of victory raises participation only through the direct individual incentive.

With Strategic Complementarity

$$\beta > 0$$

- Consider a message that raises $\bar{V}(m)$

$$A(m) = \frac{\overset{\text{Direct effect on participation}}{\downarrow} KS(0)\bar{V}(m) - \bar{R}(m)}{C - \underset{\substack{\uparrow \\ \text{Feedback from others' participation}}}{K\beta\bar{V}(m)}}.$$

With Strategic Complementarity

$$\beta > 0$$

- Consider a message that raises $\bar{V}(m)$

$$A(m) = \frac{\overset{\text{Direct effect on participation}}{\downarrow} KS(0)\bar{V}(m) - \bar{R}(m)}{\underset{\text{Feedback from others' participation}}{\uparrow} C - K\beta\bar{V}(m)}.$$

$$\frac{\partial A(m)}{\partial \bar{V}(m)} = \frac{K(S(0) + \beta A(m))}{C - K\beta\bar{V}(m)} > \frac{KS(0)}{C}.$$

A higher expected value of victory raises participation both through (i) the direct individual incentive; (ii) multiplier feedback.

Value-of-Victory Equilibrium

$m^s(V, R) \in \{m_1, m_2\}$, where $m_1 \equiv$ “mobilize”.

m^s	$R = 1$	$R = r$
$V = v^H$	m_1	m_1
$V = v^L$	m_1 with probability π	m_2

The mobilizing message mainly selects high-value states.

$$\overline{V}(m_1) = \frac{2v^H + \pi v^L}{2 + \pi} > \overline{V}(m_2) = v^L.$$

Hence,

$$A(m_1) > A(m_2).$$

Persuasion

Let A^0 denote turnout without communication:

$$A^0 = \frac{KS(0)\bar{V}^0 - \bar{R}^0}{C - K\beta\bar{V}^0}.$$

Let ex ante turnout in the value-of-victory equilibrium be

$$A^s = \Pr(m_1)A(m_1) + \Pr(m_2)A(m_2).$$

Persuasion

Let A^0 denote turnout without communication:

$$A^0 = \frac{KS(0)\bar{V}^0 - \bar{R}^0}{C - K\beta\bar{V}^0}.$$

Let ex ante turnout in the value-of-victory equilibrium be

$$A^s = \Pr(m_1)A(m_1) + \Pr(m_2)A(m_2).$$

Proposition

If $\beta > 0$, then $A^s > A^0$. If $\beta = 0$, then $A^s = A^0$.

Persuasion

Let A^0 denote turnout without communication:

$$A^0 = \frac{KS(0)\bar{V}^0 - \bar{R}^0}{C - K\beta\bar{V}^0}.$$

Let ex ante turnout in the value-of-victory equilibrium be

$$A^s = \Pr(m_1)A(m_1) + \Pr(m_2)A(m_2).$$

Proposition

If $\beta > 0$, then $A^s > A^0$. If $\beta = 0$, then $A^s = A^0$.

Intuition

- The messages redistribute turnout: $A(m_1) > A^0 > A(m_2)$.

Persuasion

Let A^0 denote turnout without communication:

$$A^0 = \frac{KS(0)\bar{V}^0 - \bar{R}^0}{C - K\beta\bar{V}^0}.$$

Let ex ante turnout in the value-of-victory equilibrium be

$$A^s = \Pr(m_1)A(m_1) + \Pr(m_2)A(m_2).$$

Proposition

If $\beta > 0$, then $A^s > A^0$. If $\beta = 0$, then $A^s = A^0$.

Intuition

- ▶ The messages redistribute turnout: $A(m_1) > A^0 > A(m_2)$.
- ▶ If $\beta = 0$, the probability-weighted gain and loss cancel.

Persuasion

Let A^0 denote turnout without communication:

$$A^0 = \frac{KS(0)\bar{V}^0 - \bar{R}^0}{C - K\beta\bar{V}^0}.$$

Let ex ante turnout in the value-of-victory equilibrium be

$$A^s = \Pr(m_1)A(m_1) + \Pr(m_2)A(m_2).$$

Proposition

If $\beta > 0$, then $A^s > A^0$. If $\beta = 0$, then $A^s = A^0$.

Intuition

- ▶ The messages redistribute turnout: $A(m_1) > A^0 > A(m_2)$.
- ▶ If $\beta = 0$, the probability-weighted gain and loss cancel.
- ▶ If $\beta > 0$, the feedback multiplier is larger after m_1 :

$$\frac{1}{C - K\beta\bar{V}(m_1)} > \frac{1}{C - K\beta\bar{V}(m_2)}.$$

Key message

Leadership communication is persuasive because it changes how strongly each citizen responds to others' participation.

What about repression?

Repression Changes Rhetoric

$m^s(V, R) \in \{m_1, m_2\}$, where $m_1 \equiv$ “mobilize”.

m^s	$R = 1$	$R = r$
$V = v^H$	m_1	m_1
$V = v^L$	m_1 with probability π	m_2

The mobilizing message mainly selects high-value states.

At $(v^L, 1)$, the leader sends m_1 with probability π .

Repression Changes Rhetoric

$m^s(V, R) \in \{m_1, m_2\}$, where $m_1 \equiv$ “mobilize”.

m^s	$R = 1$	$R = r$
$V = v^H$	m_1	m_1
$V = v^L$	m_1 with probability π	m_2

The mobilizing message mainly selects high-value states.

At $(v^L, 1)$, the leader sends m_1 with probability π .

As repression intensifies,

$$\frac{d\pi}{dr} < 0 :$$

Repression Changes Rhetoric

$m^s(V, R) \in \{m_1, m_2\}$, where $m_1 \equiv$ “mobilize”.

m^s	$R = 1$	$R = r$
$V = v^H$	m_1	m_1
$V = v^L$	m_1 with probability π	m_2

The mobilizing message mainly selects high-value states.

At $(v^L, 1)$, the leader sends m_1 with probability π .

As repression intensifies,

$\frac{d\pi}{dr} < 0$: **m_1 becomes a cleaner signal of v^H .**

Repression and Rhetoric

Belief response

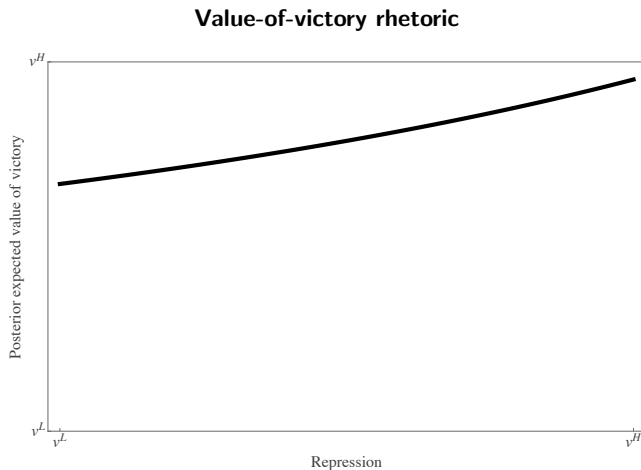


Figure: Posterior expected value of victory after the mobilizing message m_1 .

Repression can induce leaders to concentrate rhetoric on the value of victory.

Illustrative formulations

- ▶ “Freedom is worth the ultimate price.” **Nelson Mandela, 1964**
- ▶ “Do or die.” **Mahatma Gandhi, 1942**
- ▶ “Demands for democracy require a collective willingness to endure hardship.” **Aung San Suu Kyi, 1991**

Repression and Rhetoric

Belief response

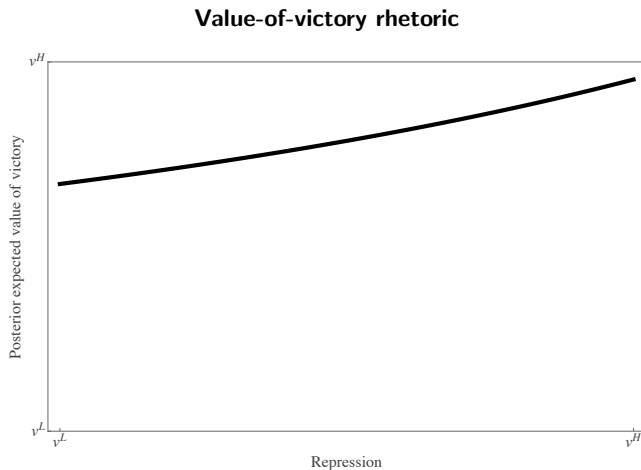


Figure: Posterior expected value of victory after the mobilizing message m_1 .

Repression and Rhetoric

$$\underline{\beta} < \beta < \overline{\beta}$$

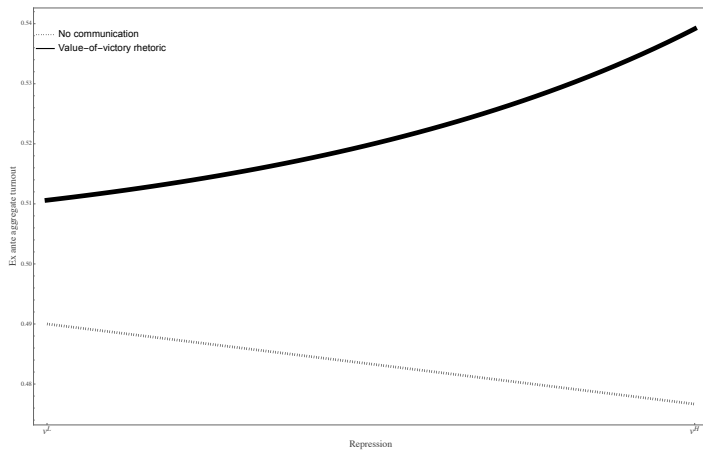


Figure: Under value-of-victory rhetoric, repression can increase aggregate turnout.

Summary

Implications

1. Strategic interaction between receivers drives persuasive communication
2. Leadership communication mobilizes by making others' actions more consequential.
3. Repression can make protesters believe that victory would produce historical transformation
4. Whether repression mobilizes depends on both leadership communication and the political dimension that the communication emphasizes.

Regime-Weakness Equilibrium

m_1 : mobilizing message

m^w	$R = 1$	$R = r$
$V = v^H$	m_1	m_1 with probability α
$V = v^L$	m_1	m_2

The mobilizing message mainly selects low-repression states.

Proposition

If $\beta > 0$, then aggregate turnout when communication is centered on the value of victory (A^s) exceeds aggregate turnout when communication emphasizes regime weakness (A^w):

$$A^s > A^w > A^0.$$

Conclusion

- ▶ **How can materially weak opposition groups use public communication to mobilize participation?**
- ▶ A multidimensional cheap-talk model in which communication reveals information about the value of victory and the repression citizens will face.

Results

1. Cheap talk can mobilize citizens under repression.
2. Value-of-victory rhetoric is powerful because it activates a coordination multiplier.
3. Repression can strengthen the effect of value-of-victory rhetoric.
4. Informative communication improves citizens' welfare.